Political Struggle during the Middle Ages (920 – 1250 CE)

By the early 10th century, the Carolingian dynasty had run its course and the Vikings had created settlements of their own throughout Western Europe. In the east, the Magyars controlled the region and in North Africa, the Fatimids were in power. Hugh Capet was elected king of France in 987 CE but he was considered to be weak by the feudal nobles. The king and his heirs were expected to act in accordance with the feudal organization. However, the king used these concepts for his own interests. He was ambitious and won various lands through political influence and warfare.

At the end of the 11th century, Louis VI had enough power to dominate the feudal lords in both title and in strength. His successor Louis VII faced the Angevin Empire, which was governed by the Plantagenets. In 1066, William the Bastard defeated the English forces and replaced the Anglo-Saxon culture with that of the Normans'. Since the Angevin Empire had ties through marriage with its enemies, it was considered to be dangerous by the French kings. In 1214 at the Battle of Bouvines, Philip II Augustus met Otto IV and John of England in battle and was able to conquer them. John returned to England full of shame and was forced to sign the Magna Carta. Louis IX ruled France well and gained a reputation as a wise leader.

What is modern day Germany today was once a formidable kingdom during the mid-10th and mid-11th centuries. Feudalism had been banned from the reign of Otto I. The German king defeated the Magyars in 955 at Lechfield and then continued to rule since he had control over the Church. This allowed him to effectively bypass the nobles and their demands. In 962, he became the next Holy Roman Emperor while his sons Otto II and Otto III followed in his footsteps. All of them appointed various Popes, bypassed the nobles and supported new reforms within the Church. Papal reforms occurred in the monasteries that pushed the belief that only the Pope should be allowed to make decisions concerning Church matters. These new tensions that became prevalent during the reign of Henry IV and Gregory VII ultimately caused the Papal-German Investiture Controversy.